

Discipline Disability is Not Individual: Looking Closely at How a Smart Kid is Being Disabled

Abstract

As with learning, we always celebrate or disparage students' discipline (dis)ability, frequently judged as an individual property and labeled as a fixed trait. However, by looking closely at the process of being disabled, we argue that discipline disability is cultural work organized within a specific context and complex interactions. And it is better described as a culture that stops at classification and aims to cause harm, rather than a fact about a specific child. Moreover, we highlight how discipline disability intersects with learning, suggesting that classroom discipline should not come at the expense of students' learning. Consequently, we emphasize that once there is a decontextualized, individual notion of ability, there will inevitably be a DiSmart characterized by discipline disability.

"DiSmart is smart but has discipline issues."

New stories emerged after looking closely:

"I have a different opinion of DiSmart now, a significant change... I didn't really know what was happening within the group, but after watching the video..."

Purposes

Sadly, we saw a smart kid (whom we'll call DiSmart) suffering in the science class. Unlike the disability to learn, DiSmart is captured as disabled by the discipline culture that is particularly emphasized in Chinese primary school classrooms (Lewis et al., 2005). First, this extends the understanding of "culture as disability" (McDermott & Varenne, 1995) to the more specific cultural work of discipline in the classroom. While we often acknowledge the necessity of classroom discipline and focus on teachers' classroom management (Lopes & Oliveira, 2017), relatively little attention has been paid to how a child is being disabled in discipline issues. By looking closely and tracing the process of transgressing, we argue that discipline disability is not an individual or inherent attribute but rather contextually and collectively organized. It can even be said that each of us participates in the creation of these transgressions.

Moreover, less consideration is given to how discipline intersects with curiosity and science learning, resulting in a smart child who is curious and loves science, suffering moments of being disabled and a fragile relationship with science. Consequently, we further reinforce the argument that McDermott's (1993, 2006) criticism of the school as a cultural system intentionally designed to make specific children look bad. No one can pass through this trap unscathed.

Perspectives

Discipline Disability is not individual but collectively and culturally organized, which is derived

from thinking about Learning Disability as a cultural preoccupation and production (McDermott et al., 2006). In this sense, DiSmart must be seen in terms of the people with whom he interacts and the ways in which they structure their activities together (McDermott & Varenne, 1995). And "context is not so much something into which someone is put, but an order of behavior of which one is a part" (McDermott, 1993, p. 290). Consequently, degradation is always a ritual on the stage we call school, meaning that a person must do the wrong thing that everyone is expecting someone to do, and at just the right time. This is exactly what DiSmart experienced.

It is necessary to clarify why we specifically use the term "Discipline Disability." Firstly, we consider "disability" rather than "issue", because his disciplinary issues have been labeled as negative traits by teachers and classmates, causing his suffering and difficult situation at school, rather than merely a result of occasional mistakes. And just as learning is seen as an ability, following rules is also perceived as an ability, thereby producing disability in the same way. Secondly, learning disabilities may encompass and thus obscure discipline disability in some contexts. For instance, in McDermott's (2006) insightful case, the emphasis remains on Hector, who performs poorly academically but contributes the most in group work, rather than on Boomer, who faces discipline disability. Nonetheless, DiSmart undoubtedly struggles with discipline every day, rather than with learning. We believe that Boomer/DiSmart's discipline disability also need to be critically examined.

Methods

We crafted the case study which is emergent from my field work but so "telling" (Mitchell, 1984, p. 239) to reveal the cultural work of discipline disability. Specifically, we draw on a micro-level analysis of video data and video-cued interviews (Tobin et al., 1989, 2009) to crystallize (Richardson, 2000).

Methodologically, McDermott (2006) emphasizes that we must look closely to avoid the institutionalized neglect of kids' ingenuity and understand what it means for a kid's behavior to be at risk when it unfolds in relationships with other children and teachers. Nearly everyone who has closely looked at learning biographies finds it easier to see what children can do rather than focusing on their visible failures (McDermott & Raley, 2011). As the teacher said, "*I realized his transgression were unintentional. I used to think he often took things from other kids or was domineering, but today I saw he respects his peers.*" Consequently, we compared the common label and preconceived judgments of discipline disability with the videos we recorded, thereby questioning the original simplistic narrative. Furthermore, this methodological shift urges us to answer entirely different questions (McDermott & Raley, 2011), specifically, how discipline disability is generated in context rather than just how to deal with them.

Data

Data includes science classroom videos, interviews, and field notes, all collected through participant observation and recorded by the author. First, the core data consists of three episodes in which DiSmart experienced discipline disability, covering the themes of the magnet and shadow. Secondly, we conducted informal interviews and 150 minutes of video-cued interview with the science teacher focused on DiSmart. As Tobin(2009) said, “each thing in the video is a question, not data,” which helped us understand the teacher's more complex views on discipline issues and DiSmart. We also plan to conduct video-stimulated recall interviews(Morgan, 2007) with DiSmart and his group members this September.

DiSmart attends a mid-to-upper-level public primary school in a developed region of China. The school emphasizes science education and has a lively teaching atmosphere. The science teacher, with a master's degree in science education and seven years of experience, focuses on fostering scientific thinking rather than strictly enforcing discipline. Despite this inclusive and open-minded approach, DiSmart still experiences being disabled.

Findings

DiSmart's invisible ingenuity (will be provided in the full paper and presentation), along with his frequent transgressions observed by the teacher—especially his “injuries” within the group—highlight moments of being disabled, revealing his fragile relationship with science. These “should-not-be” moments urge us to consider that discipline disability is not individual and how current classroom discipline hampers science learning.

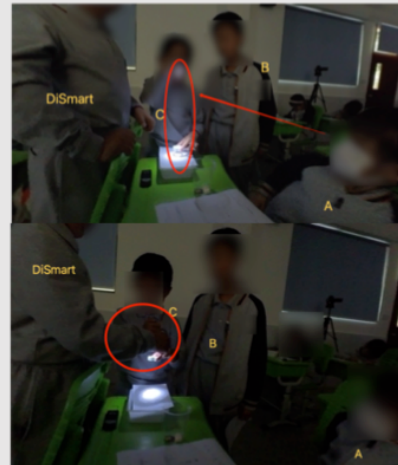
Discipline disability is collectively constructed

Discipline disability is an interactive product organized by all participants and specific contexts. For example, DiSmart was criticized by the teacher for playing with magnets when he wasn't supposed to. However, just two seconds earlier, his group mate had also been holding the magnet but put it down before the teacher arrived.

A more complex and convincing example is how DiSmart did exactly what everyone expected him to do wrong and was placed on the teacher's visible stage at just the right time. However, this was merely an unintended mistake due to a lack of instructional support. The specific contexts and interactions contributing to his disability included, but were not limited to: the positions and body postures of the four students, Student A feeling dazzled just before this incident, the coincidental arrival of the teacher, the constant echo of “*He shone it in my eyes*” from other groups, and Student B, who often conflicted with DiSmart and was likely dazzled by lights from other groups. The detailed analysis is as follows(Figure 1):

When **C** was using the flashlight, **A** moved away (till out of the screen), and whispered, "*It's a bit dazzling*".

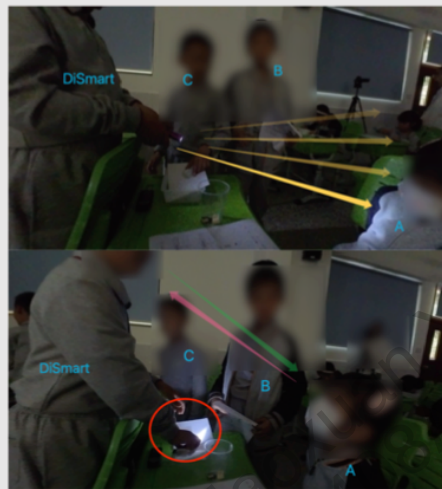
DiSmart stared at the phenomenon created by **C** intently and remarked that it looked like a wheel. As the wheel grew larger, DiSmart exclaimed, "Wow, wow," and then reached out, attempting to take the flashlight. Meanwhile, **A** remained hiding at a distance to avoid the "*dazzling*".



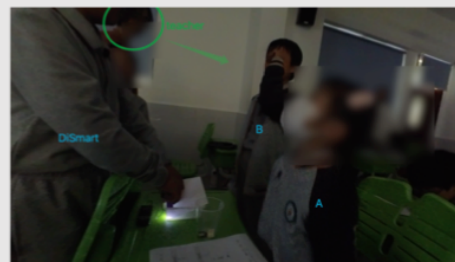
As DiSmart took the flashlight from **C**, the light shone on **A**, which was likely due to DiSmart's and D's **face-to-face and up-to-down positioning**.

Immediately, **A** sat up straight and loudly said, "*DiSmart! You shone it in my eyes.*"

DiSmart quickly responded, "*Sorry, sorry, I didn't mean to,*" and put down the flashlight.



As the **teacher** occasionally approached the group (Two seconds after DiSmart apologized), **B** covered his eyes and shouted, "*You shone it in my eyes too.*" (B might have been dazzled by light from another group, as indicated by the light spots on the back wall and B's clothes before and after A was shone. **However, it was not from DiSmart.**)



After the teacher noticed and asked what happened, **A** stood up and told the teacher, "*DiSmart just shone the flashlight in my eyes,*" while **B** continued to gesture towards his face and verbally reinforce the complaint.

The end was that the **teacher** concluded, "*You did shine it in their eyes, I saw it,*" and marked the "safe use of flashlight" item as bad performance on their learning sheet.



Figure 1 The First Transgression

Unfortunately, DiSmart was again disabled in the next experiment, even though he had not actually shone the light on his peers (Figure 2). As McDermott (1993) pointed out, "Everyone knew how to look for, recognize, stimulate, make visible, and, depending upon the circumstances, keep quiet about or expose Adam's problem":

DiSmart was handing the flashlight to **C**, and it was difficult to see from the video whether the flashlight directly shone on C (C said nothing) .



However, **A** looked at DiSmart and said, "Why are you shining it in someone's eyes again?" DiSmart responded, "**I didn't.**" **B** immediately got emotional and said to DiSmart, "*You shone it in my eyes.*" DiSmart replied, "**I was giving it to him (C), I went in his direction.**" As B stammered, "You, you, you,"

C spoke for the first time, looking at DiSmart and saying, " Oh, by the way, **can't you turn off the lights first?**" **B** angrily leaned in and stared at DiSmart, saying, "**Yeah, why did you keep the light on? It shone on me.**"

Coincidentally, at that moment, the **teacher** appeared behind B and was talking to the whole class. **B** immediately walked towards the teacher to complain, while DiSmart tried to explain.

The teacher, as seen from the video, intended to de-escalate the situation. The story ended with the teacher saying, "**He already shone it in their eyes, let it go,**" quickly redirecting their attention back to the experiment.




DiSmart

C

B

A

DiSmart

B

teacher

DiSmart

teacher

B

A

Figure 2 The Second Transgression

DiSmart faced collective criticism and unjust accusations from his peers. And he had two consecutive bad performances seen by teachers, further reinforcing his "discipline disability" label. However, upon carefully looking the entire process, we believe DiSmart's behaviors were at most unintentional or clumsy. His biggest mistake might have been not thinking to turn off the flashlight before handing it over (in fact, C, who suggested this strategy, did not do it either when handing it to DiSmart). As the teacher mentioned after watching the video, *"I usually think they don't follow rules because the teacher didn't explain clearly or didn't know how to avoid mistakes, like turning off the flashlight first. I often reflect on this myself."*

In fact, DiSmart is not inherently clumsy. During the insect specimen observation, we saw him deftly handle a long and fragile mechanical pencil lead, engaging in many "risky" interactions with the specimen without breaking the lead all along. Compared to the specific moments of not following the rules, in the majority of unseen moments, he respects his peers rather than forcing his ideas on them, and follows rules when reminded by his peers rather than just seeking to satisfy his own curiosity.

Discipline disability intersects with curiosity and learning

In the episodes of the magnet and shadow, DiSmart's opportunities for curiosity and inquiry are shut down by discipline disability (Doyle, 1986). We suspect that, at least in the Chinese cultural context, disciplinary disability might be even less acceptable than learning disabilities (Haberman & Richards, 1990). For example, a child who rarely participates in "doing science" often manages to "not get caught not knowing something" (McDermott & Raley, 2011, p.381). Yet, DiSmart's strong desire to inquire often draws attention, putting him at risk of discipline disability, which is not limited to science class. The teacher mentioned, *"Sometimes he feels down and doesn't speak up, possibly because he was disciplined in other classes or by the head teacher, who is closely monitoring him, which is quite common."* Ultimately, learning ceases to be a pleasure; it becomes a struggle (Bekerman and Zembylas, 2018).

The acquisition of DiSmart by discipline disability

Whether intentional or not, our school system strives to make students' transgressions visible. The *context* implies the order of behavior in which people participate (1993). When the act of shining a light on someone only becomes a scoring item as punishment, yet no one teaches how to do the right thing and instead assumes that someone must fail, the existence of a DiSmart becomes inevitable. It can be reasonably inferred that if, when DiSmart made his first transgression, we had not just marked an "X" on his evaluation sheet but instead told him that when passing the flashlight, one could turn it off first to avoid shining it on others, he might not have ended up in the second unfortunate situation.

Thus, rather than saying DiSmart disrupted discipline, it is more accurate to say that discipline needs DiSmart to exist. Rather than labeling DiSmart as disabled, it is more accurate to say that we collectively construct DiSmart's disability, with the world organized to make his disability visible (Hood, McDermott, & Cole, 1980).

Significance

Although it is commonly understood that we should not label students, this suggestion is often made from the perspective of potential outcomes such as self-fulfilling prophecies (Jussim, 1986). We emphasize that not labeling is not merely a moral requirement or expectation, but fundamentally because discipline disability itself is not an individual trait detached from context.

Moreover, we imply the intersection and hierarchy among cultures, suggesting that visible discipline disability is prioritized over invisible curiosity. We suggest that students' learning should not be sacrificed for classroom discipline, and we should strive to understand the process and potential curiosity behind transgressive behavior while just stopping or punishing it (Lopes & Oliveira, 2017; Närhi et al., 2015).

Consequently, we cannot hope to produce ability from a system designed to produce disability, nor can we avoid producing disability from a system designed to produce ability. The nature of existing school discipline is often not what Kant described as "out of duty," but rather "conform to duty." Its purpose is not to learn but to eliminate and cancel all possibilities and complexities outside the rules, reducing behavior to a binary opposition of compliance and non-compliance (He & Kang, 2024). Both this case and teachers' reflections in interviews suggest that the purpose of rules should be to help students avoid mistakes, rather than merely identifying failures.

We attempt to deliver a critical attack and reimagination on the existing culture of school aimed at exclusion through the case of the "smart child." It is not merely for a "better" yet optional aspiration, but because we witness the tangible suffering and the heartfelt confusion of "how could we let a child endure this," creating an imperative desire to change.

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